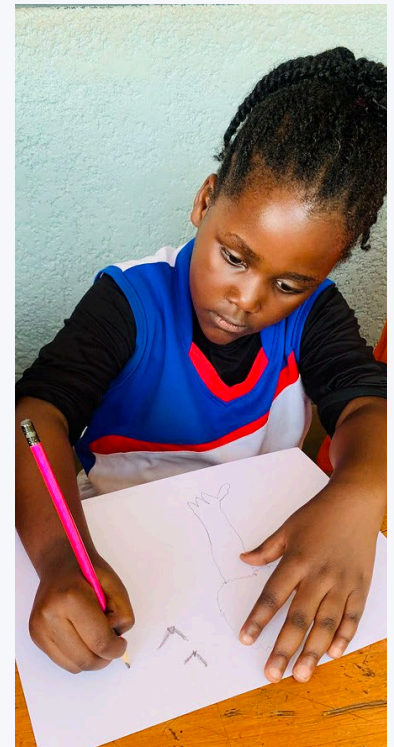


# EMPOWERING HER FUTURE



**VISIONS  
AND  
ACTION  
FOR THE  
GIRL  
EFFECT**



**AT CLUB RAFIKI**

**31-07-2025**

# INTRODUCTION

## BACKGROUND

Club Rafiki is a non-profit organization operating in Rwanda in Nyarugenge district since October 24,1974. In 2012 club Rafiki joined hands with indigo foundation and started Urban dance school (UDS) a program that offers dance classes for young people aged between 6 and 18 years old. Before the collaboration the center has been a hub for cultivating talents through sports and providing sexual and reproductive health education programs, laboratory testing service for pregnancy, and voluntary testing and counselling of HIV and STIs since 2010.

Through this partnership, club Rafiki got access to extra funds through fundraising and donation with the aim to expand the center programs. Here are the programs that were established: *My talent, my health (in 2013)*, *Because we are the future (in 2014)*, *English corner workshop-ECW (in 2017)* and lastly Our girl program (in 2018). These additional programs have contributed tremendously to the role club Rafiki plays in the community and benefitted a lot of youth who attend the center programs.

## IMPORTANCE OF GENDER INCLUSION

Our girl program was established to promote and encourage girls and women to attend the center programs and feel included. Even though club Rafiki has always been inclusive to both boys and girls, over the years the gap between girls and boys attendance to the center’s programs has been wider where boys and men attended on a larger scale than girls and women.



*“ It wasn’t easy to break the barriers and beliefs embedded in our society due to culture norms where girls and women were encouraged to stay home and take care of house chores but through constant education and proof that when girls and women are given the space and voice to showcase their talents they can also positively contribute to their community parents and our community have embraced the center. Though we have come a long way we still have a lot of work to do.”- Stephanie Alamba , legal representative of club Rafiki*

At club Rafiki we believe that girls and boys can impact the society positively when given the right tools, that is why programs like our girl are established, to help the girls and women in their specific needs catch up and close the gap between them and their male counterparts.

## OBJECTIVES OF THE DOCUMENTATION

- Highlight the programs that have been implemented in partnership with Indigo foundation to empower girls and women.
- Assess their social and economic impact on the community club Rafiki operates in.
- Assess the gap between girls and boys in accessing and being included in programs offered by the center.
- Propose improvements to ensure that the programs are tailored for the needs of the intended beneficiary.

## METHODOLOGY

### DATA COLLECTION METHODS

The data used in this document was collected during one to one interviews, group discussions, analysing feedback and review from previous surveys and reports.

### TARGET GROUP

The data was collected by engaging various stakeholders including: club rafiki staff. Young participants involved in different programs, coaches and trainers and parents of the beneficiaries of the programs run by club Rafiki.

### CURRENT STATUS OF GIRLS' PARTICIPATION

Using the last ten years as a benchmark to analyse the participation of girls across club Rafiki's services, you will find that there has been a significant rise in female attendance..

| Year      | Male    | Percentage | Female  | Percentage | Total   |
|-----------|---------|------------|---------|------------|---------|
| 2016/2017 | 223,500 | 71%        | 92,500  | 29%        | 316,00  |
| 2024/2025 | 409,538 | 66%        | 213,353 | 34%        | 622,891 |

From the data shown in the table above, both male and female numbers grew significantly, but female numbers grew at a faster rate boosting their share from 29% to 34%. These changes are results of programs (such as tailoring, our girl space, etc) tailored for girls and campaigns put in place to encourage girls and women to attend and participate in the youth center programs.

This shift marks a clear and steady improvement in gender inclusion and engagement of young women particularly in areas where they were previously underrepresented.

## **TYPES OF ACTIVITIES**

Our girls program works with girls and women to build their skills and confidence through mentorship, capacity building training, sexual reproduction health education and digital literacy.

The program helps with sanitary products to girls and women who can't afford them, equip them with education about their sexual health in order to make better decisions and offer a safe space for girls and women to talk about their daily struggles.

They offer monetizable skills through projects like tailoring classes, handcraft project, braiding training, dances classes, and so much more

Building their confidence and offering them hope through initiatives like sauti ya dada.

## **CHALLENGES FACED BY GIRLS IN ACCESSING OR PARTICIPATING IN PROGRAMS**

One of the challenges girls face is cultural and society beliefs, where girls were meant to care for the matter of the house and not encouraged to participate in sport activities or other entertainment activities.

Another challenge is that most of the house chores are delegated to girls and that leaves them little free time to attend the program activities.

Parents believing that their daughters will not be safe at the center because there are boys and men on the premises.

## VOICES OF THE GIRLS

At the heart of every successful program are the voices of the people who participate in them. This section highlights the thoughts, feelings, and suggestions shared by girls from our girls program in Nyamirambo, Mageragere and Kanyinya.

We spoke with girls involved in Urban dance school, tailoring, basketball, handcrafts, badminton and SRH education. Their voices tell us what they love, what they wish for, and how the programs have impacted their life.

### WHAT THE GIRLS LOVE

Many girls shared that coming to club Rafiki feels like entering a second home, a space where they can be themselves, learn new things, get their problems solved and build confidence.



*"Rafiki is like a home to me, I have been coming here since i was kid and been into multiple programs like badminton, dancing and tailoring."- Amina 19 years old, club Rafiki*

*" When I'm dancing, i forget all my worries. I feel free and strong."- Lily 13 years old, Mageragere*

Girls also mentioned how much they enjoy making friends from different places, sharing ideas and having a place where they feel heard.

### NEW CONFIDENCE AND SKILLS

For many girls , these programs are not just about learning a new skill, they are about growing as individuals. Girls in karate for instance, talked about how the classes have helped them feel more confident and safe.



*" Before karate, i used to be shy and scared to speak. Now i am good at it and i represent my club in competition" Uwase 13 years old, club Rafiki.*

Others spoke proudly about handcrafts and tailoring, which allow them to express creativity and think about their futures.





**Tailoring first cohort graduation!**



*“ When I first started sewing class, i couldn’t even pedal the machine and i remember the teacher used to tease me but now i have my own sewing machine and i make clothes for a living!”- shakira 30 years old, tailoring graduate*

**LEARNING ABOUT LIFE AND HEALTH**

Girls who attend our girls' mentorship sessions talked about how much they have learned about their life, especially sexual reproductive health, things that are not often discussed at home or school.



*“Before, i felt ashamed to talk about matters regarding SRH and asking questions but now i know about my body. My rights and how to stay healthy” - Vestine 26 years old, Club Rafiki*

*“ i learned that i have a choice about my future. I want to finish school before anything else.”- Aline 15 years old, Kanyinya*



## Girls receiving sanitary products

These sessions are helping girls make informed decisions, protect themselves and speak up for their health and well-being.

### WHAT THE GIRLS WISH FOR

While many girls are happy with the program, they also have ideas on how to make it even better. Some girls from kanyinya and mageragere mentioned that they would like more projects.



*“They are girls who don’t come here because there is only modern dance, if you can bring traditional dance or fashion, there would be more girls attending and also with more projects we can explore our hidden talents.” a girl in mageragere*

Others asked for sanitary products, continual advocacy for sexual reproductive health and female mentors to look up to.

These voices remind us that girls are not just participants, they are dreamers, thinkers, leaders and changemakers. Their experiences and ideas should guide how we grow and improve the program moving forward.



# OUR GIRL THROUGH MEN LENSES

Dedicated programs for girls play a crucial role in empowering young women, fostering leadership, building self confidence, and addressing unique challenges they face. While these initiatives are vital, it's equally important to explore how they are perceived from the perspective of boys and men.

Understanding the male point of view can offer valuable insights into how these programs impact the wider community, shape gender dynamics, and influence boys' attitude toward equity and inclusion. Some boys view girls' targeted programs with curiosity or admiration, recognising its value, while others may feel left out or question its exclusivity. By opening up this conversation, we create space for mutual respect, understanding, and collaboration across genders ensuring that all youth regardless of identity feel seen,heard and included in the journey toward a more equitable society.



*“ I am a karate coach and a parent, I coach both boys and girls. Having girls in programs like these equip them with self-defense skills that could be helpful when they are outside, also doing karate builds discipline and confidence and keeps them away from getting involved with bad company which can lead to drug abuse or unplanned pregnancy. Girls were not encouraged to join karate because it was regarded as a sport of vagabonds but with time people have seen that it is a myth and encouraged their daughters to join. Boys and men have embraced training with girls and they really encourage them to be their best selves, and now we have women who represent us and come with medals.” - Coach Saidi*







*" i grew up hearing that there are things girls and women cannot do, i am always astonished when i see that they can do the same things i can do. I have a sister and i would like for her to be part of some program here.the skills they offer here can generate money, i see girls booked for dancing gigs and that gives them financial freedom."- Manzi 18years old, UDS club rafiki*



*"I have never had prejudices against girls because when i joined UDS there were girls, but back then the society viewed modern dance as a taboo and girls who were dancers were not regarded well in the society. As a coach, we encourage healthy competitions among boys and girls to push themselves to be better. Girls are now confident, they can teach and secure jobs and gigs, this boosts their confidence and the money helps them to solve some little problems without depending on men. Attending and working in the club has exposed me to knowledge about what girls and women face, i have received training about SRH and that gives me confidence to serve my students better." - Emmanuel, UDS trainer*



*" girls can do everything boys can do. At home boys and girls do house chores. I don't believe girls are weak but i would feel bad if a girl was faster than me in a running race. If a girl in my class were to stain her skirt when she is in period, i would not be shy to let know because i wouldn't want others to see it and probably laugh at her. I love dancing with my sister because when we get home we can practice our steps together.." - from a group discussion with boys aged between 9 and 14 years old from UDS Mageragere*



This survey revealed that most boys and men have a supportive and respectful view of girls'targeted programs. They see these initiatives as valuable spaces that empower girls. These findings highlight a positive shift toward gender respect and allyship among the youth in our community.

# PROGRAM REVIEW AND ASSESSMENT

## RELEVANCE OF EXISTING PROJECTS

Many of the current projects at the center were designed with a general youth population in mind but do not sufficiently encompass specific interests for every girl that the center serves. When we had a group discussion with girls in Mageragere they expressed that they would love to have traditional dance classes and a fashion club. Lack of having certain activities especially in Kanyinya and Mageragere may be a reason for limited interest in the program. This indicates a need for more diversified projects in rural areas.

## ACCESSIBILITY AND SCHEDULING

Accessibility is not an issue given that every program has specific time to avoid conflict in schedules, and also their timetables are set with students and workers' availability in mind so that the club programs don't interfere with their studies or work. However, some girls are not able to attend regularly because of household responsibilities.

Also the club premises are built to enable people using a wheelchair to access the center without a problem. However we don't have enough resources to cater to other different forms of disabilities.

## SAFE AND INCLUSIVE ENVIRONMENT

A safe, inclusive and welcoming environment is essential for girls's full engagement. Every girl and woman we talked with reported that they have always felt safe and have never experienced discrimination or harassment while attending the center programs. And the youth center regularly ensures that the space is safe and welcoming to every attendant.

## GENDER SENSITIVITY AND STAFF PREPAREDNESS

We are confident with our staff and volunteers capacity to engage with girls in a gender sensitive and empowering way. Our staff are competent to support girls effectively, especially those who are shy, have experienced discrimination or face socio-cultural restrictions. With that said, we recommend regular gender sensitivity training and having a present female mentor on every site that girls can talk to in case they don't want to talk to their male coaches.

## SOCIAL AND ECONOMIC IMPACT

This program has had a profound social and economic impact on the lives of girls who attend the center. By offering inclusive access to services such as vocational training, ICT skills, employment support, sexual and reproductive health education and creative arts, the center is equipping girls and young women with the tools they need to build brighter futures.

Socially, these programs foster confidence, self-expression, and informed decision making. Girls gain not only knowledge but also a sense of community, belonging and purpose. Participation in outreach activities and safe spaces for dialogue allows them to address sensitive issues such as reproductive health, gender based violence and social pressures, breaking cycles of silence and disempowerment.

Economically, access to skills training and job seeking services is helping girls become more financially independent. Whether it's through learning tech skills, vocational skills, participating in cultural industries or gaining employability support, many young women are now able to generate small income to support themselves and their families and contribute to their communities.

Overall, club Rafiki's programs are helping to close the gender gap, promote gender equity and empower girls to become agents of change in both their personal lives and community.





## RISKS OF STOPPING THE PROGRAM AND MITIGATION STRATEGIES

### RISKS OF STOPPING THE PROGRAM

Discontinuing the girls targeted programs at the youth center could lead to several negative consequences, including:

- **Loss of safe and supportive spaces:** these programs often provide a safe environment where girls can freely express themselves, build confidence and access mentorship. Without this support, many participants may feel isolated or less empowered.
- **Increased vulnerability:** the programs play a critical role in addressing key issues such as gender-based violence, reproductive health and life skills. Removing these services may leave girls without the tools and knowledge needed to navigate challenges safely and confidently.
- **Reduced engagement in the youth center:** ending the programs may lead to a drop in overall participation among girls, weakening the gender balance and inclusivity of the center's activities.
- **Undermining long-term impact:** many of the benefits of girls targeted programs such as leadership development, education continuation, and improved mental health are long term. Interrupting this progress could reverse gains already made.
- **Damage to stakeholder trust:** abruptly stopping the program may affect the credibility of the youth center among participants, families, community partners and funders, potentially impacting future support or collaboration.

### MITIGATION STRATEGIES

To prevent or manage the negative consequences of stopping the program, the following steps are recommended:

- **Secure sustainable funding:** explore diverse funding options, such as partnerships, grants, community sponsorships or crowdfunding campaigns to ensure program continuity.
- **Integrate key components into broader programs:** if full continuation is not possible, embed essential elements of the girls targeted initiatives (e.g., mentorship, health education, leadership training) into general youth programs to maintain access and impact.
- **Engage the community:** involve girls, parents, and community leaders in discussions about the future of the program to ensure their needs and concerns are heard and to build local ownership and support.
- **Develop a transition plan:** if discontinuation is unavoidable, establish a clear transition strategy that connects participants to alternative resources or services in the community to reduce the disruption of support.
- **Advocate for policy support:** work with local authorities or institutions to recognize the importance of gender focused youth programs and to advocate for integration into public services or education systems.

## IMPROVEMENT AND RECOMMENDATION

Based on the findings from the survey on girls targeted programs, this section outlines key areas for enhancement and provides actionable recommendations. The insights gathered from participants highlight both the strengths of current initiatives and opportunities to better meet the needs and girls engaging with the center.

The following suggestions are intended to guide the development of more inclusive, relevant and impactful programming that empowers girls and promotes their active participation.

- Keep running girl's targeted programs that teach sexual reproductive health, leadership and their rights.
- Give girls a safe space that promotes inclusion, and offer them opportunities and roles that get them outside their comfort zone like being MC in club's events.
- Create a mentorship program "back to my roots initiative" where girls who attended club Rafiki mentor new girls in the club and contribute to their development and assist existing staff.
- Work hand in hand with parents and local leadership to encourage girls to join initiatives like our girls.
- Organize a parent meeting where we make sure that our message is complimentary and encourage parents to have discussions with their children regarding SRH and mental health.
- Deploy a monitoring and evaluation system to assess the girls input and plan where to add more efforts.
- Place a female mentor on every site especially in rural areas whom girls can talk to easily.
- Prepare a girl's room at the club which women can use in case they experience menstruation issues while attending the center.
- Establish projects aimed to detect and promote talents especially for girls and women.

# CONCLUSION.

Many of the current projects at the center were designed with a general This documentation provides valuable insights into the experiences, needs, and expectations of girls and women participating in the programs.

While current initiatives have made a positive impact in several areas such as creating safe spaces, offering skill building opportunities and fostering peer connection. There remain gaps that require attention to ensure these programs are fully inclusive, relevant, and empowering. By integrating the feedback from participants and implementing the recommended improvements, club Rafiki has an opportunity to strengthen its commitment to gender responsive programs and better support the development of girls.

